

LIMINAL *window*

The Poetics of Appetite: *A Practice-Based Investigation of Language in an Ice Cream Menu*

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Abstract

This study examines the linguistic strategies employed within a successful commercial ice cream menu and investigates the extent to which poetic mechanisms contribute to perceptions of desirability, appetite, and consumer engagement. Through close reading and the creation of a found poem composed exclusively from menu language, the study explores sound patterning, lexical selection, imagery, and syntactic compression. Findings suggest that the menu relies heavily upon poetic devices typically associated with literary writing, despite functioning primarily as a commercial document.

Keywords

poetics, rhetoric, menus, commercial language, found poetry, practice-based research,

Introduction

Poetry is often regarded as a literary genre distinct from everyday communication. Yet many forms of public language rely upon the same mechanisms poets use to create imagery, emotion, and memorability.

This study investigates a simple question:

How does an ice cream menu use language to make products appear desirable?

The investigation began during the composition of a found poem created entirely from language appearing on an ice cream menu. During the selection process, recurring linguistic patterns emerged that appeared to contribute to the menu's effectiveness.

Methodology

The primary source material consisted of a commercial ice cream menu. Language from the menu was collected and rearranged into a found poem *without* introducing additional vocabulary.

The menu was then examined for recurring patterns including:

- Sound repetition

- Lexical selection
- Color imagery
- Sensory imagery
- Syntactic structure
- Omission of grammatical connectors

Observations made during the creative process were documented and analyzed.

Findings

Lexical Compression

One of the most notable discoveries was the near-complete absence of connective words such as “*of*” and the infrequent use of “*with*.” Instead of phrases such as:

“*Chocolate with vanilla*”

or

“*Cream of vanilla*”

the menu consistently favored compressed constructions such as:

“*Chocolate vanilla cream*”

This compression creates a more immediate reading experience. The removal of grammatical connectors allows sensory nouns to sit directly beside one another, producing a denser and more evocative sequence of associations. The result resembles poetic compression, in which articles and connective words are frequently omitted in favor of stronger image concentration.

Sound and Appetite

The menu displayed a noticeable recurrence of long vowel sounds, particularly within words associated with sweetness, creaminess, and indulgence.

Words such as:

- Cream
- Creamy
- Sweet
- Milky

appeared repeatedly throughout the menu. While further research would be required to establish a causal relationship, these sounds appeared consistently within descriptions intended to communicate indulgence, richness, and sweetness. The prevalence of these sounds raises the possibility that phonetic qualities contribute to perceptions of desirability in commercial language.

Imagery and Color

Explicit color terminology appeared infrequently within the menu language despite the inherently visual nature of the product. Green appeared only once and was associated with the only explicitly artificial descriptor in the menu: “candy.” The scarcity of color language contrasted with the abundance of sensory and textural language. Rather than emphasizing visual color, the menu relied upon words associated with:

- Cream
- Vanilla
- Coldness
- Sweetness

These lexical choices collectively produced an atmosphere of softness, richness, and comfort.

The Language of Cream

The *most* recurring image throughout the menu was cream itself. Even when describing flavors that could stand independently, descriptions frequently returned to cream-oriented vocabulary. For example, chocolate flavors were rarely presented solely as chocolate. They appeared alongside cream, vanilla, milk, or other dairy-related language. This repeated invocation of creaminess appears to reinforce an idealized sensory image associated with ice cream itself. The menu was not merely selling flavor. It was repeatedly selling texture, temperature, and sensation.

Found Poetry as Research

The creation of the found poem served as a form of practice-based research.

As words were selected and rearranged, it became apparent that many of the same lexical choices that made the menu appealing as a commercial document also made it effective as poetic material. The language functioned successfully in both contexts because both contexts relied upon imagery, sound, association, and emotional suggestion.

This observation supports the central hypothesis of the study:

Commercial language frequently employs poetic mechanisms to influence audience response.

Summer Sundae

Confetti cherries
with birthday berries,
and a buttercream brownie
with sweet house honey,

with the darkest
brambleberry
sugarcookie
cream,
in a

burnt butter cone in candy green.

Comparative Observation

Following this investigation, a second restaurant's menu was also examined. Unlike the first ice cream restaurant, which was selected because of its popularity and high customer volume, the second establishment was a smaller and less prominent business. The menu appeared to rely more heavily on photographic imagery and less on descriptive language. Many flavor names were generic descriptors that identified products rather than evoking sensory experiences. Flavors such as:

- Cotton Candy
- Vanilla
- Peach
- Mango Ice

During peak hours, and the same time as the other restaurant, there was a noticeable difference in customer volume observed. While numerous factors likely contribute to differences in customer volume, the contrast raises questions concerning the relationship between descriptive language, visual imagery, and consumer engagement. While no definitive conclusions can be drawn from this limited comparison, the contrast suggests a promising area for future research.

Conclusion

This study suggests that commercial menus frequently employ poetic mechanisms including imagery, sound patterning, lexical compression, and sensory association.

The language of the menu did not merely communicate information about products. It actively constructed an imaginative experience intended to influence perception and desire.

The findings support a broader proposition underlying the Liminal Window project: poetic mechanisms are not confined to literary texts but operate throughout everyday communication.

Future research may explore the relationship between descriptive language, consumer behavior, visual imagery, and rhetorical effectiveness across additional commercial environments.

Future Research Questions

- Do menus with stronger descriptive language outperform menus relying primarily on photography?
- Are certain vowel sounds associated with perceptions of sweetness?
- Does lexical compression increase menu readability?
- How does language influence purchasing decisions in food-service environments?

This paper forms part of the ongoing Liminal Window research initiative investigating poetic mechanisms in everyday language.

References

Primary Source:

- Anonymous commercial ice cream menu. Field transcription and documentation by the author. Durham, North Carolina. June 2026.

Appendix A: Ice Cream Menu Transcription

Sizes

- Standard (*2 Half Scoops*)
- Signature (*3 Half Scoops*)
- Study (*4 Half Scoops*)

Classic Flavors

- Goat Cheese with Red Cherries
- Buttercream Birthday Cake
- Brambleberry Crisp
- Brown Butter Almond Brittle
- Darkest Chocolate
- Double Dough
- Goopy Butter Cake
- Green Candy Chip
- Honey Vanilla Bean
- House Coffee
- Milkiest Chocolate
- Banana Cream Pudding
- Peppermint Patty
- Salted Peanut Butter with Chocolate Flecks

Limited Flavors

- Burnt Orange Dreamsicle
- Frosted Sugarcookie
- Strawberry Buttermilk
- Matchapolitan
- Confetti Brownie Batter
- Summer Berries & Passion Fruit
- Sweet Cream Biscuits & Peach Jam

Features & Pairings

- Milk & Cookies
 - Double Dough
 - Milkiest Chocolate
 - Honey Vanilla Bean
 - Brown Butter Almond Brittle
 - Milkiest Chocolate
 - Salted Peanut Butter with Chocolate Flecks

Special

- Summer Signature
 - Matchapolitan
 - Summer Berries & Passionfruit
 - Banana Cream Pudding
 - Buttercrisp Waffle Bowl

Additional Items

- Buttercrisp Waffle Cone or Bowl
- Sundae Fudge Sauce
- Strawberry Sauce

Appendix B: Comparative Menu Transcription

Core Flavors

- Vanilla
- Coconut
- Chocolate
- Strawberry
- Butter Pecan
- Banana Pudding
- Cappuccino Crunch
- Salty Caramel Truffle
- Peanut Butter Cookie Dough
- Cookies & Cream
- Cotton Candy
- Bourbon Truffle
- Rum Raisin

- Tequila
- Kahlua

Seasonal / Limited Flavors

- Vegan Mango Ice
- Vegan Lemon Sorbet
- Pistachio
- Orange Vanilla
- Tiger Tail
 - Vanilla
 - Fudge
 - Butter Pecan

About The Author

Jaiden Hordosillo is a poet, publisher, and literary scholar.

He believes that no poetry is bad. Not because all poetry is great, but because every poem written from a place of genuine feeling carries human value. To read poetry is to encounter another person's experience, and through that encounter, better understand both others and ourselves.

His work is dedicated to the preservation and publication of poetry, and to the belief that poetry belongs to everyone regardless of background, education, or circumstance.

Through writing, publishing, research, and community engagement, he seeks to encourage a culture in which poetry is not viewed as an academic luxury, but as an essential human practice.

"Poetry is the most human form of language."